

29 April – 1 June 2027

Five weeks from a Bristol base: tulips in the Netherlands, the Highlands and Skye, and Gaudi's Barcelona. No car on any leg.

FLIGHTS AND TRANSFERS

Thu 29 Apr	Cathay Pacific, direct	HKG 08:05 → LHR 15:15 (14h10)
Thu 29 Apr	National Express coach	Heathrow → Bristol coach station. Brian collects after work.
Sat 1 May	KLM Cityhopper, direct	BRS 10:45 → AMS 13:00 (1h15)
Sat 8 May	KLM Cityhopper, direct	AMS 16:45 → BRS 17:00 (1h15)
Mon 17 May	easyJet, direct	BRS 11:40 → EDI 12:55 (1h15)
Sat 22 May	easyJet, direct	EDI 08:05 → BRS 09:20 (1h15)
Thu 27 May	easyJet / Ryanair, direct	Bristol → Barcelona, about 2h. Morning departure.
Mon 31 May	easyJet / Ryanair, direct	Barcelona → Bristol, about 2h. Latest evening departure.
Tue 1 Jun	National Express coach	Bristol → Heathrow, about 2h30. Early-afternoon coach.
Tue 1 Jun	Cathay Pacific, direct	LHR 20:15 → HKG 15:45 next day (12h30)

THE MONTH AT A GLANCE

Thu 29 – Fri 30 Apr	Arrive Heathrow, settle into Bristol. Rest days.
Sat 1 – Sat 8 May	Netherlands. Keukenhof on the bank holiday Monday.
Sun 9 – Sun 16 May	Bristol base. Bath, the Cotswolds, Wells.
Mon 17 – Sat 22 May	Scotland. Edinburgh and a three-day Highlands and Skye tour.
Sun 23 – Wed 26 May	Bristol base. Devon, South Wales, day trips.
Thu 27 – Mon 31 May	Barcelona, with a day trip to Montserrat.
Tue 1 Jun	Repack in Bristol, coach to Heathrow, fly home.

BRISTOL BASE — PREMIER SUITES BRISTOL REDCLIFFE

Address	30–38 St Thomas Street, Redcliffe, Bristol BS1 6JY
Telephone	+44 117 954 4800
Nights	29–30 Apr, 9–16 May, 23–26 May, 31 May (about 17)
To Bedminster	15 min walk over Bedminster Bridge

Tulips, windmills and canals

Four nights in Leiden, three in Amsterdam. Trains, buses, bikes and boats throughout.

Sat 1 May Day 1 • Arrival, Leiden

- 10:45 → 13:00** KLM Bristol → Amsterdam Schiphol
- Border: allow 45 min for biometric checks on first entry
- Train Schiphol → Leiden Centraal, 15 min, direct from under the terminal
- 14:30** Check in, drop bags
- 15:30** Hortus Botanicus Leiden — the garden where Dutch tulip growing began in 1593
- Evening** Canal walk through the old town, early dinner

TRAIN

NS, about €6pp. Tap in and out with a contactless card.

STAY

Leiden, 4 nights (1-4 May). Near Centraal or the old town.

TIP

Stay up until 21:00 local. Fighting the nap fixes the jet lag.

Sun 2 May Day 2 • Delft and The Hague

- Train Leiden → Delft, 25 min. Markt square, Nieuwe Kerk, Vermeer's canals
- Royal Delft pottery works — hand-painting demonstrations
- Train on to The Hague, 12 min
- Mauritshuis — Girl with a Pearl Earring. Two hours is plenty
- Optional: Scheveningen beach, 15 min by tram
- Evening** Back to Leiden for dinner

WHY TODAY

A gentle second day. Monday is the big one.

BOOK

Mauritshuis timed entry online.
mauritshuis.nl royaldelft.com

Mon 3 May Day 3 • The bulb region — UK bank holiday

- 07:20** KeukenhofBuzz bus 854 from Leiden Centraal, about 30 min
- 08:00** Keukenhof, earliest timed slot. Far end first, then work back
- 10:30** Whisper-boat tour through the bulb fields, 45 min, from inside the park
- 12:00** Kasteel Keukenhof, 10 min walk. Castle, parkland, lunch
- 14:00** Bikes from the Keukenhof entrance. Flat 8-12 km field loop
- 15:15** Annemieke's Pluktuin — pick your own tulips
- 16:30** Bikes back, bus 854 to Leiden

BOOK — OFFICIAL

Tickets on sale autumn 2026 (site currently says mid-November). Book the 08:00 slot on release day.
tickets.keukenhof.nl keukenhof.nl/en [Plan your visit](#)

COMBI TICKET

Entry + bus 854 in one booking. Add the boat tour at the same time — it sells out.

BIKES

About €15pp, e-bikes available. If not cycling: taxi between stops, about €15 a hop, book via the hotel.

KASTEEL KEUKENHOF

Separate ticket, limited opening days — confirm 3 May.

Tue 4 May Day 4 • Rotterdam and Kinderdijk

- Train Leiden → Rotterdam Centraal, 35 min
- Markthal and the Cube Houses
- 11:00** Waterbus from Erasmusbrug to Kinderdijk — 19 windmills, UNESCO listed
- Two working mills open inside. Allow 2–2.5 hours including the boat
- Back to Rotterdam: Erasmusbrug and the harbour
- 19:30** Back in Leiden

BOOK

kinderdijk.com waterbus.nl

REMEMBRANCE DAY

20:00 national two-minute silence. The whole country stops. Eat early — some restaurants stop at 19:45.

Wed 5 May Day 5 • To Amsterdam — Dam, cruise, Jordaan

- 10:00** Train to Amsterdam Centraal, 35 min. Check in, drop bags
- 12:30** Guided walking tour from Dam Square — Royal Palace, Nieuwe Kerk, Begijnhof, canal ring
- 15:00** Tulip Tour canal cruise, Flagship Amsterdam — bright afternoon light
- 17:00** Liberation Day — free open-air festivals
- 19:00** Jordaan on foot: Westerkerk, Noordermarkt, hidden hofjes, Nine Streets. Dinner at a brown café

STAY

Amsterdam, 3 nights (5–7 May). Canal ring or Jordaan. Confirm there is a lift.

TULIP CRUISE

Mid-afternoon departure, not dusk. Seasonal — confirm it sails in early May 2027.

flagshipamsterdam.com

WALKING TOURS

Dam: free tip-based tours (Sandemans, Free Walking Tours Amsterdam), reserve online.
Jordaan: Gilde Amsterdam small-group walks, book by email.

Thu 6 May Day 6 • Giethoorn day trip

- 08:00** Depart Amsterdam
- Train to Steenwijk, about 2h via Zwolle, then bus 70, 15 min
- A village with canals instead of streets — thatched farmhouses and footbridges
- Whisper boat for an hour or two, electric and easy to drive yourselves
- Lunch canalside, then the footpath loop
- Evening** Back in Amsterdam for dinner

INFO

giethoorn.com

TWO WAYS

By train and bus (about €30pp return) or a coach day tour (€60–80pp, boat included). The coach is easier.

BOAT

About €35–40 per hour for the boat. Book ahead in May. Arrive before 11:00 or after 15:00.

Fri 7 May Day 7 • Flower market and Zaandam

- 09:30** Bloemenmarkt — the floating flower market on the Singel, trading since 1862
- 11:15** Train to Zaandam, 17 min
- Inntel Hotel — seventy Zaanse houses stacked seventeen storeys high
- 12:30** Zaanse Schans: working windmills on the river

BLOEMENMARKT

Mon–Sat about 09:00–17:30. Partly souvenir stalls now — an hour's browse.

BULBS HOME

Buy sealed certified export packs and check

- Catharina Hoeve cheese farm — demonstration and tasting, free
 - Kooijman wooden shoe workshop — a clog carved in five minutes, free
 - Inside one working mill, about €6
- 17:00** Back to Amsterdam

Hong Kong rules first.

ZAANSE SCHANS

The village is free. Only individual mills and the museum charge.

dezaanseschans.nl

Sat 8 May Day 8 • Van Gogh Museum, then home

- 09:00** Van Gogh Museum, first slot — his work hung in the order he painted it
- Two hours. Check out first, leave bags at the hotel
 - Lunch, last canal walk
- 13:30** Train to Schiphol, 20 min
- 16:45 → 17:00** KLM Amsterdam → Bristol

BOOK

Timed entry, online only, no door sales.

vangoghmuseum.nl

CHECK FIRST

Confirm KLM flies AMS–BRS on Saturdays.

AIRPORT

Allow 2h30 at Schiphol for exit checks.

Edinburgh and the Highlands

Edinburgh at either end, and a three-day small-group tour to the Isle of Skye in the middle. Long daylight, and no midges yet.

Mon 17 May Day 1 • Arrival, Old Town

11:40 → 12:55	easyJet Bristol → Edinburgh
14:00	Tram to St Andrew Square, 35 min. Check in
15:30	Royal Mile towards Holyrood, via Victoria Street and Greyfriars
Evening	Calton Hill for the view. Sunset about 21:30

TRAM

£7.50pp single, every 7 min.

STAY

Near St Andrew Square — tram and tour departures are both there. Hotel stores the big cases during the tour.

Tue - Thu 18-20 May Day 2 • Highlands and Skye — 3-day tour

Tue 08:00	Departs central Edinburgh. Stirling, then Glencoe, night in Fort William
Wednesday	Isle of Skye: the Cuillins, Portree, Old Man of Storr or the Quiraing. Night on Skye
Thursday	Eilean Donan Castle, Loch Ness, Fort Augustus. Back in Edinburgh 19:00–20:00

BOOK EARLY

May departures fill months ahead. Book the tour before hotels.

rabbies.com

ROOMS

Booked separately after the seat. Ask for en-suite twin, ground floor.

LUGGAGE

About 14kg each, one cabin-size bag.

PACK

Layers, waterproof, proper shoes.

Fri 21 May Day 3 • Edinburgh, slowly

10:00	Edinburgh Castle
•	Royal Botanic Garden — peak rhododendron season, free
•	Stockbridge, Dean Village, Water of Leith
•	If wet: National Museum of Scotland, free
Evening	Early dinner, pack

BOOK

Castle timed entry online.

edinburghcastle.scot rbge.org.uk

Sat 22 May Day 4 • Early flight home

05:45	Taxi to the airport, 25 min
08:05 → 09:20	easyJet Edinburgh → Bristol
•	Home before lunch

TAXI

Book the night before, about £30. Don't rely on the tram at this hour.

Gaudí and the sea

Four nights in the Eixample, one day out to Montserrat. Late May is about 23°C.

Thu 27 May Day 1 • Arrival, Gothic Quarter

- Morning flight Bristol → Barcelona, about 2h
 - Aerobús to Plaça de Catalunya, 35 min
 - Cathedral and the Barri Gòtic lanes
 - El Born and Santa Maria del Mar
- Evening** Tapas in El Born

STAY

Eixample, between Plaça de Catalunya and Passeig de Gràcia. Not on La Rambla.

DINNER

Starts at 21:00 in Spain.

PICKPOCKETS

La Rambla and the metro. Nothing in back pockets.

Fri 28 May Day 2 • Gaudí

- 09:00** Sagrada Família, first slot — morning sun through the east windows
- Lunch, then Passeig de Gràcia
 - Casa Batlló inside, Casa Milà from outside
 - Rest at the hotel
- Evening** Gràcia — small squares, local restaurants

BOOK

Sagrada Família sells out weeks ahead. Official sites only.
sagradafamilia.org casabatllo.es

Sat 29 May Day 3 • Montserrat

- 08:30** R5 train from Plaça Espanya, about 1h
- Rack railway up the mountain
 - Basilica and the Black Madonna. Boys' choir about 13:00 most days
 - Sant Joan funicular for the views
 - Back in the city by six

BOOK

Combined train + rack railway ticket.
montserratvisita.com

SHOPPING

Do it today. Many shops close Sundays.

Sun 30 May Day 4 • Park Güell and the sea

- 09:30** Park Güell, early timed slot. Taxi up — the walk is steep
- 13:00** Seafood paella at Barceloneta, then the promenade
- Cable car to Montjuïc Castle, or rest
- Evening** Pack

BOOK

Monumental zone is timed and capped.
parkguell.barcelona

Mon 31 May Day 5 • Last morning, fly home

- Check out, bags at the hotel
- La Boqueria market — closed Sundays, so today

OPEN

An ordinary working Monday in Barcelona.

- Palau de la Música guided tour
- Aerobús to the airport, evening flight home

palaumusica.cat

NEXT DAY

Coach to Heathrow, 20:15 to Hong Kong.

Before you book

- ☐ **UK ETA** for both, well before travel. Passports valid 6 months past 1 June 2027.
- ☐ **ETIAS** for the Netherlands and Spain, expected live in 2027, €20, over-70s exempt.
- ☐ **Keukenhof** tickets + bus 854 + boat tour, the day they release.
- ☐ **Tulip cruise** Flagship Amsterdam, afternoon of 5 May.
- ☐ **Van Gogh Museum** 09:00 slot on 8 May, online only.
- ☐ **Giethoorn** train or coach tour, then the whisper boat.
- ☐ **Highlands tour** 3-day Skye tour before any Scottish hotel.
- ☐ **Sagrada Família** plus Park Güell and Casa Batlló.
- ☐ **Premier Suites Redcliffe** about 17 nights across four blocks — ask for one rate.
- ☐ **Travel insurance** the whole 29 Apr – 1 Jun window.

Online version with photos: brianskcheng.github.io/joyce-family-europe-trip-2027